

Virtue: Confucius and Aristotle - Jiyuan Yu

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Structural Similarity

“Virtue” is translated from the latin word “virtus” where “vir” translates as “manhood”

Category	Arete	Ren
Etymology	Excellence of manly qualities	Noble hunstmen, manly/manhood
Philosophical Origin	Aristotle	Confucius
Philosophical Subject	Human function	Human Relatins
Philosophical “Definition”	Good performance/Excellence of the human function ¹	Part 1: “to love man”, Part 2: “to return to li” ² ³

Ethos and Practical Wisdom

“Li is thus the totality of socially acceptable behavior patterns and lifestyles, including both moral and non-moral norms. It corresponds to Aristotle’s ethos (social custom), that is, the traditional social mores and cultural settings” (Pg 326)

The “return to li” for Confucius refers to returning to the lif of the Zhou dynasty. Confucius believes that the reason behind social turmoils of his time was the “loss of traditional values of the Zhou culture” (Pg 327).

Aristotle believes in conformity to the prevailing social customs because of the social nature of humans and the difference between a “good man” and a “good citizen”.

Be reflective toward *ethos* (social custom) through phronesis in order to be a good person. Phroensis is needed because:

1. Understand why behaviours are noble and true
2. Compare various views of what goodness is
3. Understands context / particulars (Universals vs Particulars)

According to Yu, “Confucius’ notion of yi [righteousness] seems to open the door for an Aristotelian practical wisdom, but he fails to work it out. He has a major virtue called “wisdom” (zhi), but it must also be based on conformity to li” (Pg 331)

¹Broken into Intellectual virtue (excellence in exercising reason) and Ethical virtue (excellence of obeying reason). Intellectual virtue has both theoretical wisdom and phronesis (practical wisdom) and phronesis is both shaped by virtue and is what materliazes virtue.

²“the translation of li ranges from”rites” to “propriety,” “ceremony,” “decorum” and “manners”” (Pg 324)

³Need for both parts (EX: Bank Robber): “fond of ren without being fond of learning is liable to lead to foolishness” “Learning means to learn li, to recognize it and embody it in one’s behavior” (Pg 324)

Filial Love and Self-love

“Filial piety and brotherly love are the roots of ren” (Pg 332) is centered around this idea that “a good father makes a good ruler, a good son makes a good subject” (Pg 332).

For Aristotle, love/friendship is “intrinsic to a happy life” (Pg 334). Unlike Confucius, Aristotle believes these relationships are all “an extension of one’s love of oneself rather than an extension of filial love” (Pg 335)

Cultivation

Category	Arete	Ren
Term of Success	<i>hexis</i> “having”	<i>de</i> “to get”
Process	Habit, developing <i>phronesis</i> , golden mean. A state of being ⁴	<i>jiaoyu</i> (education) = <i>jiao</i> (teaching) + <i>yu</i> (nurturing) ⁵⁶

Yu ends with a few remarks that Aristotelian virtue would benefit from the insights of filial love and that a Confucian revival needs a developed notion of rationality and assessment of tradition.

Discussion Questions

Should one draw a distinction between good man and citizen? Do you believe in the existence of a universally ideal society?

Do you believe that your relationships with your family or that your relationship to yourself most strongly shapes your relations with other? (or secret third option)

Can virtue be taught and/or learned? Are virtue and ethics the same to you? What does living a virtuous life mean for you? (09/09 we covered notions of purpose and roles in society)

⁴“virtue is a state (*hexis*) concerned that decides, consisting in a mean, the mean relative to us, which is defined by reference to reason i.e., to the reason by reference to which the person of practical wisdom would define it” (Pg 340)

⁵Centered around notions of role models as educators, fathers and rulers. Model-Copy -> Teacher-Pupil -> Father-Son.

⁶Single thread of “Zhong and Shu”, with *Zhong* being doing one’s best and *Shu* like reciprocity.